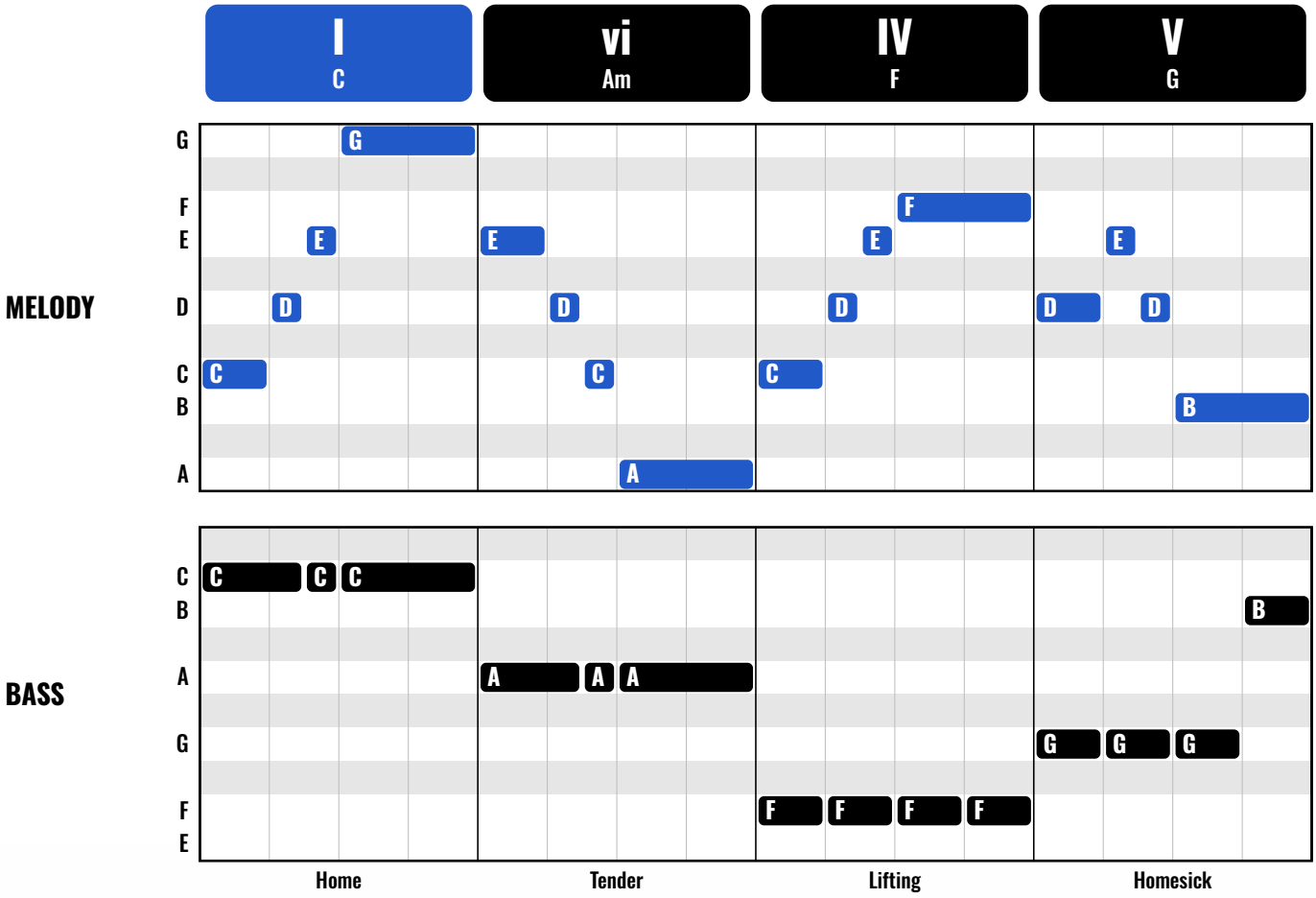
HUDSON BEAT



MELODY WRITING IN LOGIC PRO

BASS & MELODY

DMP1 · Unit 4 · basslines that follow the roots · melodies you can hum

GRADES 9–12 · 4 DAYS · 30 PAGES + 22-SLIDE DECK

BASS & MELODY WRITING

How to use this resource

START HERE

Teacher

WHAT THIS IS ·

A complete 4-day bass and melody unit for high school music technology. Days 1 and 2: students use a scale to write a short, singable melody over a chord progression and bassline they already have. At the end of Day 2 they look hard at that bassline and discover the rule behind every bassline. Day 3: they choose four chords with Roman numerals and write their own bassline. Day 4: they present both.

This is Unit 4 of my Digital Music Production 1 course. It picks up where Unit 3, Chords by Ear (a separate resource), ends: students continue in their Unit 3 project. Students who did not do Unit 3 use your chords-and-bassline file (recipe on page 4) and the Reference Cards in this kit. C major or A minor, white keys only. No music reading is needed.

QUICK START ·

1. Read the overview and pacing (pages 3–6) and the teacher notes (pages 9–12).
2. Check who has a Unit 3 project; for everyone else make the chords-and-bassline file once (10 minutes, page 4).
3. Cue up Seven Nation Army (The White Stripes) and Stand by Me (Ben E. King) on YouTube or Spotify.
4. Print the student pages (pages 13–26), one set per student.

THE INTRO DECK ·

Every slide has a day: Day 1 (slides 1–10), Day 2 (slides 11–15), Day 3 (slides 16–20) and Day 4 (slides 21–22). The day plans name the slide for each block. Every slide has speaker notes.

Fonts: the deck uses Oswald and Source Sans 3 (free on Google Fonts, built into Google Slides). If PowerPoint or Keynote shows a different font, install the two fonts or present the PDF copy, which shows the intended look.

WHAT'S INSIDE ·

PART	PAGES	USE
Teacher pages	pages 2–12	How to use, overview, setup + the Logic file, Logic reference, pacing, day plans, teacher notes
Student pages	pages 13–26	Two classroom posts, packet Part 2 (scales) and Part 4 (basslines), Reference Cards, four ways to write a melody, two project sheets with their rubrics, vocabulary
Answer keys + examples	pages 27–29	Packet answers, a worked melody and a worked bassline in both keys
Intro deck (separate file)	deck	22 slides, .pptx + PDF, speaker notes on every slide

ABOUT THE SONGS

Songs are named by title (and artist) only. Play them from your own YouTube or Spotify access; no audio, video or lyrics are included.

MAKE IT FIT YOUR CLASS ·

- **File names:** the project sheets keep my naming rule, "Your Name — Building Blocks Part 2" and "Part 4" (The Building Blocks is my name for this theory sequence). Change it to suit your class.
- **Grading:** each project has my /15 rubric. My course plan treats this unit as a check-in; if you prefer that, use the submission checklists alone.
- **More accessible / more advanced:** variations on page 12.
- **No MIDI keyboard?** Musical Typing (Command-K), click-in or the step sequencer works for every step.

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Unit overview

OVERVIEW

DMP1 · Unit 4

WHAT STUDENTS MAKE ·

A bassline and short melody written over a chord progression in Logic: the foundational skills a full-song or EDM project will require. Two short projects: a 2- or 4-measure melody over the chords and bassline from Unit 3 (or your file), then an original bassline over four chords each student chooses from the Reference Card.

WHAT STUDENTS LEARN ·

Basslines are monophonic — one note at a time. The root of each chord is the safest and most powerful bass note. Melody is short, repetitive, and singable. Quantize exists and it is not cheating. The scale gives you a guaranteed set of notes that will sound right. Four methods of writing melody: play in, draw a rhythm first, click one note and move it, use the step sequencer.

WHY THIS UNIT LANDS HERE ·

Unit 3 gave students the harmonic landscape. This unit teaches them how to move through it — one line at a time. Bass anchors the bottom, melody defines the top. These are the two skills the EDM project requires but currently cannot assume. Teaching them here, with no other pressures, means students can focus entirely on the musical challenge.

MIXING CONCEPT: FREQUENCY SEPARATION ·

Bass and melody stacked together sound muddy. A brief EQ introduction gives students the tool to solve the problem they just created: high-pass the melody, roll off the extreme highs of the bass.

GOALS ·

- Use a scale as the ingredient list for a melody
- Write a short, singable melody that starts or ends on the root
- Enter notes by playing in (and quantizing) and by clicking in
- Discover and state the bassline rule: the bass changes to the root of the new chord
- Choose four chords with Roman numerals and explain the feeling they create
- Write a monophonic bassline with at least two rhythmic ideas
- Give bass and melody their own frequency homes with EQ

AT A GLANCE ·

Grades	9–12 (no music reading needed)
Length	4 periods of about 53 minutes: intro, two work days, present
Keys	C major or A minor, white keys only
Software	Logic Pro: piano roll, record + quantize, Pencil, step sequencer, copy and paste, Channel EQ, export
Product	A melody project and a bassline project, each an MP3 + compressed project; packet Parts 2 and 4; a planning table
Assessment	Two 3-category rubrics, /15 each (pages 22 and 25)

STANDARDS ·

Supports the National Core Arts Standards for Music (Music Technology, high school): developing musical ideas (MU:Cr2.1), refining work (MU:Cr3.1) and presenting work (MU:Pr6.1).

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Setup and requirements

SETUP

Teacher

YOU NEED ·

- **A Mac with Logic Pro** and **headphones** for each student; a MIDI keyboard (an MPK Mini or similar) if you have one.
- **A piano sound on the class speakers** for the Day 1 scales and demos.
- **Projector** for the deck; **two songs** from your own YouTube or Spotify access: Seven Nation Army (The White Stripes) and Stand by Me (Ben E. King).
- **Printed student pages**, one set each: two posts, packet Parts 2 and 4, the Reference Cards, four ways to write a melody, both project sheets and rubrics, vocabulary.
- **A chords-and-bassline Logic file** for every student (right).
- **A place to submit** an MP3 and a .zip, and a class feedback board for Day 4 (I use Padlet).

BEFORE DAY 1 ·

- ☐ List who has a Unit 3 project; make and share your file for everyone else.
- ☐ Test the class speakers; cue up the two songs.
- ☐ Check that students can play notes: MPK Mini (find OCT +), or Musical Typing (Command-K).
- ☐ Print the student pages; set up the submission spot and the feedback board.

THE LOGIC FILE: CONTINUE FROM UNIT 3

Students who did Unit 3 already have it: their Part 3 project is a bassline plus four chords. On Day 1 they open it and save a copy as “Your Name — Building Blocks Part 2”, then add the melody on a new track. On Day 2 the bassline in the same file is the one they analyze.

NO UNIT 3 PROJECT? MAKE THE FILE ONCE (10 MINUTES)

My recommended setup for the Part 2 file:

- C major or A minor key — white keys only for accessibility
- 4 chords, one per measure (the recipe below)
- Bassline using root notes of each chord
- Arrangement markers labeling each section
- No melody track — leave that blank for students to fill in

Recipe (one chord per measure, as in the Unit 3 project):

1. New project, a Software Instrument track with a bass sound (Library: Bass). A tempo between 80 and 100 BPM is comfortable.
2. Draw a 4-measure MIDI region. In the piano roll add one whole note per measure, the root of each chord, low on the keyboard. C major: C – A – F – G. A minor: A – F – C – G.
3. A second track with a piano or pad sound: the four chords, three notes stacked per measure. C major: I C - E - G, vi A - C - E, IV F - A - C, V G - B - D. A minor: i, VI, III, VII (spellings on the A minor card).
4. Turn on Cycle over the 4 measures; add arrangement markers labeling the chords.
5. Leave the melody track out: students add it. Share the project with your class.

Worked examples on pages 28–29. Logic sessions are not included in this kit.

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Logic quick reference

SETUP

Teacher

Everything students need in Logic for this unit, in one table. Demonstrate once (slides 9 and 18), then let students work.

New instrument track	Track › New Software Instrument Track (Option-Command-S). Open the Library (Y): a lead or synth for the melody, a bass sound for the bassline.
Octave up for melody	Press OCT + on the MPK Mini once before recording. With Musical Typing (Command-K), X moves up an octave and Z down.
Play it in	Turn on Cycle (C) over 2 measures. Press R to record, play, press the Space bar to stop.
Quantize	Select the notes in the piano roll (Command-A) and press Q. It fixes timing, not notes.
Click it in	Open the piano roll (P). Choose the Pencil tool (T menu) and click to add a note; drag its right edge to set the length; drag it up or down to change the pitch.
Step sequencer	Control-click the track lane and choose Create Pattern Region. Turn steps on to place notes; each row is one pitch.
Copy across	Option-drag a region to copy it, or select it and press Command-R to repeat it.
Stack a chord	Three notes in one column, same start, same length. Spellings are on the Reference Card.
No overlaps	Zoom in on the bass in the piano roll: every note must end before the next one starts.
EQ	Click the EQ area at the top of a channel strip to open Channel EQ. Melody: turn on the low cut (high-pass) and drag it up. Bass: turn on the high cut.
Export	File › Bounce › Project or Section (Command-B), MP3. In Finder, Control-click the .logicx project and choose Compress.

MELODY CHECK IN THE PIANO ROLL

One note at a time, high on the keyboard, on its own track. White keys only. The first or last note is C (C major) or A (A minor).

VERSION NOTE

Menu names are from current Logic Pro versions; older versions may differ slightly. Logic Pro is a trademark of Apple Inc., named only to describe what the unit needs. This resource is not affiliated with Apple. MPK Mini is named only as an example keyboard.

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Pacing guide · 4 days

PACING

Teacher

Four class periods of about 53 minutes, as in my course plan: an intro day, two work days and a presenting day. The melody comes first, then the bassline. Each day's full plan is on pages 7–8.

DAY	FOCUS AND GOAL	MINUTE BLOCKS	DECK
DAY 1 Intro day	**Scales + melody start** Every student has checked or built the C major and A natural minor scales, chosen a key, and started a 2- or 4-measure melody over the chords and bassline.	0–8 · The hook 8–12 · Bright or dark? 12–25 · Scales 25–32 · Two projects, four ways 32–38 · Watch me 38–50 · Write 50–53 · Save + hum it	Intro deck slides 1–10
DAY 2 Work day	**Finish the melody, meet the bass rule** Melody projects submitted. Every student has looked hard at a bassline and found the rule before you say it.	0–5 · Does it belong? 5–10 · What you turn in 10–17 · Mixing moment: frequency separation 17–35 · Finish + submit the melody 35–47 · Basslines: look before you write 47–53 · The reveal	Intro deck slides 11–15
DAY 3 Work day	**Plan + build the bassline** Progression planned with Roman numerals and root notes; chords and a monophonic bassline built in Logic and submitted.	0–12 · Plan your progression 12–18 · Watch me: roots first 18–45 · Build 45–50 · What you turn in 50–53 · Export + submit	Intro deck slides 16–20
DAY 4 Present	**Presentations** Every student presents; every student can say what key, what Roman numerals, and what they wanted it to feel like.	0–5 · Last checks 5–48 · Presentations 48–53 · Close	Intro deck slides 21–22

STUDENT PAGES BY DAY ·

Day 1	Melody post (p. 13), packet Part 2 (p. 15), Reference Cards (pp. 17–18), four ways (p. 19), melody project sheet (pp. 20–21)
Day 2	Melody rubric (p. 22), basslines post (p. 14, steps 1–3), packet Part 4 analysis (p. 16)
Day 3	Basslines post steps 4–5, bassline project sheet with the planning table (pp. 23–24), rubric (p. 25)
Day 4	Vocabulary (p. 26) and the two rubrics for scoring

MY LINE FOR THE WHOLE UNIT

"Simple and repetitive will always beat complicated and forgettable." Say it on Day 1. Say it again when a student plays you a melody that goes nowhere because they tried to use every note in the scale.

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Day-by-day plans · Days 1 and 2

DAY 1 · SCALES + MELODY START

Intro day · Intro deck slides 1–10

Goal: Every student has checked or built the C major and A natural minor scales, chosen a key, and started a 2- or 4-measure melody over the chords and bassline.

0–8 **THE HOOK** [slides 1–3] · Slides 1–3. What is a melody? Play the first 30 seconds of Seven Nation Army (The White Stripes): how many different notes, how many repeats, could you hum it after one listen?

8–12 **BRIGHT OR DARK?** [slide 4] · Slide 4. Play the C major scale, then the A natural minor scale, for the class. Ask: which sounds brighter? Which sounds darker? Do not explain yet.

12–25 **SCALES** [slide 5] · Slide 5. Students work through Part 2 of the packet (page 15): C major, A natural minor and C major pentatonic. Students who did it in Unit 3 check it against the Reference Card (pages 17–18) and play each scale.

25–32 **TWO PROJECTS, FOUR WAYS** [slides 6–7] · Slides 6–7. The four days, the melody project sheet (pages 20–21) and the four ways to write a melody (page 19).

32–38 **WATCH ME** [slides 8–9] · Slides 8–9: the worked example and a 2-minute demo. Shift the keyboard up an octave, loop 2 measures, record, quantize, copy across the progression.

38–50 **WRITE** [slide 10] · Slide 10 stays up. Students open the chords-and-bassline file (their Unit 3 project saved as Part 2, or your file), listen twice, and begin the melody. Enforce the 2-or-4-measure rule immediately.

50–53 **SAVE + HUM IT** · Students save. Exit check: hum your melody to a neighbor.

DAY 2 · FINISH THE MELODY, MEET THE BASS RULE

Work day · Intro deck slides 11–15

Goal: Melody projects submitted. Every student has looked hard at a bassline and found the rule before you say it.

0–5 **DOES IT BELONG?** · Ask two students to play their melody alongside the Logic file. Class listens. Does it sound like it belongs?

5–10 **WHAT YOU TURN IN** [slides 11–12] · Slides 11–12: the melody checklist and rubric (pages 20–21, 22).

10–17 **MIXING MOMENT: FREQUENCY SEPARATION** [slide 13] · Slide 13. Solo the bass, solo the melody, then both: muddy? Students put Channel EQ on the melody and turn on the low cut (high-pass); on the bass, the high cut.

17–35 **FINISH + SUBMIT THE MELODY** · Students complete the melody, quantize, export and submit. Early finishers add a second melody variation (page 12).

35–47 **BASSLINES: LOOK BEFORE YOU WRITE** [slide 14] · Slide 14: Stand by Me (Ben E. King), follow the bass. Then students open the piano roll of the bassline in the same file and answer the Part 4 analysis questions (page 16). Do not reveal the rule yet; circulate and ask what they are finding.

47–53 **THE REVEAL** [slide 15] · Slide 15. What did you find? Let two or three students answer. Confirm the rule and write it on the board (page 10).

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Day-by-day plans · Days 3 and 4

DAYS 3–4

Bassline + present

DAY 3 · PLAN + BUILD THE BASSLINE

Work day · Intro deck slides 16–20

Goal: Progression planned with Roman numerals and root notes; chords and a monophonic bassline built in Logic and submitted.

0–12 **PLAN YOUR PROGRESSION** [slide 16] · Slide 16. Hand out the bassline project sheet (pages 23–24). Students fill in the planning table and the why question before opening Logic. Circulate and ask: why these chords? What feeling are you going for?

12–18 **WATCH ME: ROOTS FIRST** [slides 17–18] · Slides 17–18: the worked example, then a demo: whole-note roots first, then rhythm.

18–45 **BUILD** · Full working time. New Logic file: build the four chords (Reference Card spellings), then the bassline. Key check: play the bassline alone. Does it clearly follow the chord roots? Then play it with the chords. Does everything agree?

45–50 **WHAT YOU TURN IN** [slides 19–20] · Slides 19–20: the bassline checklist and rubric (pages 23–24, 25).

50–53 **EXPORT + SUBMIT** · Students export and submit before the presentation day.

DAY 4 · PRESENTATIONS

Present · Intro deck slides 21–22

Goal: Every student presents; every student can say what key, what Roman numerals, and what they wanted it to feel like.

0–5 **LAST CHECKS** · Stragglers export and submit. Students post one question about their project on the class feedback board.

5–48 **PRESENTATIONS** [slide 21] · Slide 21. Each student plays their melody, then their bassline over their chord progression, and answers: what key, what Roman numerals, what did you want it to feel like? Classmates respond to at least 2 projects on the feedback board.

48–53 **CLOSE** [slide 22] · Slide 22: the full picture. In this unit you wrote a melody, built chords, and wrote a bassline.

CIRCULATING PROMPTS (DAYS 1–3)

- ‘Hum it for me. Could you hum it after hearing it once?’
- ‘Point to where your chord changes. Does your bass note change there?’
- ‘Tell me what you want this to feel like. Which Roman numerals would create that feeling?’

THE PRESENTATION QUESTION THAT MATTERS (DAY 4)

Why did you choose this chord progression? What did you want it to feel like? Listen for Roman numeral language: “I wanted it to feel unresolved so I ended on the V.” More on page 10.

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PART ONE: A MELODY (DAYS 1–2) ·

Part 2 makes the first musical demand: write something. The scale gives students a safe set of notes, the Logic file removes the blank-page problem, and the constraint of 2 or 4 measures prevents the endless-tinkering failure mode. By the end students should have a short, singable melody and a physical understanding of what a scale is for.

The key insight to deliver: a scale is not an exercise. It is the ingredient list for a key. Every note in a melody should come from the scale. If it does, it will sound like it belongs. That is the only rule.

My course plan adds four ways to write a melody (page 19): play it in, draw a rhythm first, click one note and move it, use the step sequencer. And the most important thing you can say in this unit: “Simple and repetitive will always beat complicated and forgettable.”

WHY A STANDALONE UNIT ·

This is a new standalone unit carved from content currently buried inside EDM project videos. Students practice bassline and melody writing before they need it in a high-stakes project. The 'start on the root of each chord' rule is introduced explicitly and repeated.

HOW THIS KIT DIFFERS FROM MY CLASSROOM VERSION

- My Building Blocks material gives Part 2 (melody) 2 days and Part 4 (basslines) 2 days plus presentations, labeled Unit 3. This kit follows the 4 days of my course plan (intro, two work days, present) and is labeled Unit 4. Part 4’s analysis and reveal move to the end of Day 2 (12 + 6 minutes instead of 15 + 10). Project sheets say Unit 4 and the days.
- Students write the melody in their Unit 3 project (it holds a bassline and four chords) or in your file, and analyze the bassline in that same file, so the basslines post says “Open the Logic file from your melody project” instead of “Download today’s Logic file”. The melody post asks for Part 2 of the packet only (Part 1 is in Unit 3).
- My LMS is written as “your class page” and my Padlet steps as “the class feedback board”.
- Fixes to my text: the A minor Reference Card’s closing line names its own chords (i, v, VII, VI), not I, V, vi; basslines post step 4 says “V to I feels resolved” (I wrote “I to V”); the setup uses one chord per measure, as in Unit 3 and every example (I wrote “4 chords, each lasting 4 measures”).
- New: the four-ways page, the frequency separation mini-lesson, the Logic file recipe, the worked examples, the answer keys and the deck.

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PART TWO: BASSLINES (DAYS 2–4) ·

Part 4 has a reveal at its center. Students have been given basslines in every Logic file so far. Now they are asked to look carefully at one and figure out the rule themselves before it is stated. The analysis section of the packet is the discovery activity. The rule box in the packet confirms what they found. This sequence — discover, confirm, apply — is more memorable than being told the rule directly.

The second half of Part 4 connects everything. Students choose a chord progression using Roman numerals from their Reference Card and write a bassline that follows those roots. For the first time, they are making a compositional decision — not just executing an exercise. The written explanation of why they chose their progression is the assessment moment that shows you whether the Roman numeral instruction actually worked.

THE REVEAL MOMENT: HOW TO FRAME IT ·

After students have completed the analysis questions in the packet and identified that the bass note always follows the chord root, bring the class back together and ask: what did you find? Let two or three students answer. Then write the rule on the board:

When the chord changes, the bass note changes to the root of the new chord.

Then say: every bassline you have ever heard follows this rule. Another One Bites the Dust. Billie Jean. Your favorite song. The rule is always the same. Everything else is rhythm and decoration on top of this one idea.

THE PRESENTATION QUESTION THAT MATTERS ·

Every student should be asked this during their presentation: why did you choose this chord progression? What did you want it to feel like?

A student who answers with Roman numeral language — ‘I wanted it to feel unresolved so I ended on the V’ or ‘I used the vi because I wanted it to feel more emotional’ — has internalized the unit. A student who says ‘it sounded good’ has not. Both are valid at this stage, but the difference tells you what to reinforce in Unit 5 and beyond.

In class I also quote my tutorial line: “Your bassline loves to sit on the root of the chord. That is the safest and most powerful note you can play.”

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COMMON STUDENT STRUGGLES · MELODY ·

Blank page paralysis: Enforce the loop-and-play rule: set a 2-measure loop over the biggest part of the progression and just play. Record anything. Students who resist starting are almost always overthinking. The prompt: play one note in a rhythm you like. Then move one note up or down.

Melodies that go nowhere: Students who try to use all 7 scale notes end up with aimless lines. Redirect them: use only 3 notes. Go up, then come back down. That is a melody.

Not quantizing: Play-in melodies with bad timing are discouraging. Show the Q shortcut immediately after the first recording attempt. Make it automatic.

Wrong octave: Students who do not shift the MPK Mini up an octave will record a melody that sits in the bass register. Show the OCT button on the keyboard before recording begins.

COMMON STUDENT STRUGGLES · BASSLINES ·

Not changing the bass note at chord changes: Walk around during working time and ask every student: point to where your chord changes. Does your bass note change there? This is the most common error and the most important one to catch early.

Polyphonic basslines: Students leave previous notes sustaining when new ones start. Zoom into the piano roll and look for any notes that overlap. Any overlap in the bass is an error.

Chord progressions chosen randomly: Students who pick chords without thinking about function will have nothing to say during the presentation. Push back before they start building: tell me what you want this to feel like. Then ask: which Roman numerals would create that feeling?

Rhythmic basslines that are too busy: A bassline that plays sixteenth notes throughout is exhausting. Redirect with a simple rule: your bassline should breathe. Give some notes room. Less is almost always more.

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SUGGESTED VARIATIONS (MELODY) ·

More accessible: Restrict students to just 3 notes from the scale. C, E, G for C Major or A, C, E for A Minor. A melody built from only 3 notes is still a real melody and removes the decision paralysis entirely.

More advanced: Ask students to write a second melody that acts as a response to the first — call and response. Or ask them to change the last measure of the melody so it ends differently on the final repetition.

MIXING CONCEPT: FREQUENCY SEPARATION (DAY 2) ·

Frequency separation is introduced here because students immediately encounter the problem — their bassline and melody sound muddy when stacked. A brief introduction to EQ: high-pass the melody to remove low frequencies it does not need, roll off the extreme highs of the bass. Students do not need to understand parametric EQ yet. They need to understand that instruments have frequency homes and mixing means giving each one space to live.

GRADING TIPS ·

- Two rubrics, each with three categories scored 2–5, for /15 each (pages 22 and 25).
- Melody: open the piano roll. In key? 2 or 4 measures? First or last note C or A? Quantized?
- Bassline: point to each chord change. Is the root there? Any overlapping notes? Two rhythm ideas? Then read the why answer.
- Worked examples and answer keys: pages 27–29.

RESOURCES ·

- The intro deck (.pptx and PDF), included. The two songs, from your own YouTube or Spotify access.

OBSERVATION NOTES ·

What worked, what to adjust, and anything worth remembering for next year.

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Classroom post

STUDENT

Day 1

SCALES & MELODY · DAYS 1–2

The Building Blocks · Part 2 · Digital Music Production 1 · Unit 4

Today you are writing your first melody in Logic. Before you touch the DAW, complete the scale pages in the packet.

Do not open Logic until you have finished Part 2 of the packet (page 15).

1. **PART 2 — SCALES** · Complete the C Major, A Natural Minor, and C Major Pentatonic scale exercises in the packet.
   Apply the formula one step at a time. Play each scale on your MPK Mini when you finish it. (Did them in Unit 3? Check them against your Reference Card.)

2. **OPEN THE LOGIC FILE** · Open your Unit 3 chords project and save a copy as Your Name — Building Blocks Part 2. No Unit 3 project? Download today's Logic file from your class page.
   A chord progression and bassline are already written. Do not change them.

3. **LISTEN TWICE** · Play the full progression from beginning to end twice before you write anything.
   What key is this in? What do the chords feel like? Where do they change?

4. **CHOOSE YOUR SCALE** · Decide whether you are writing in C Major or A Minor. Both use the same white keys — the difference is which note feels like home.
   C Major: start and end on C. A Minor: start and end on A.

5. **WRITE YOUR MELODY** · Add a new track. Choose a lead or synth sound. Use the white keys on your MPK Mini to find a short phrase — 2 or 4 measures — that you like. Record it (R) and quantize it (Q).
   Simple and repetitive will always beat complicated and forgettable.

TWO WAYS TO ENTER YOUR MELODY

Play-in: press R to record, play on the MPK Mini, press Q to quantize after.

Click-in: select the pencil tool, hold Command, and click notes into the piano roll.

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BASSLINES · DAYS 2–3

The Building Blocks · Part 4 · Digital Music Production 1 · Unit 4

Today you discover the rule behind every bassline you have ever heard — and write one yourself.

Complete Part 4 of the packet (page 16) before writing your bassline in Logic.

1. **OPEN THE LOGIC FILE** · Open the Logic file from your melody project. A bassline is already written. Open the piano roll and look at it carefully.
   Do not change anything yet. Just look.

2. **PART 4 — ANALYSIS** · Complete the analysis questions in the packet. What note does the bassline play when each chord is happening?
   You are looking for the pattern. What does the bass note have to do with the chord?

3. **THE REVEAL** · Read the rule in the packet. Does it match what you found in your analysis?
   Every bassline you have ever heard follows this rule.

4. **PLAN YOUR PROGRESSION** · Fill in the chord planning table in the packet. Choose 4 chords from your Reference Card using Roman numerals. Write the root note for each.
   Think about what you want it to feel like. V to I feels resolved. Ending on V feels unfinished.

5. **WRITE YOUR BASSLINE** · Open a new Logic file. Build your chord progression, then write a bassline that follows the roots. Start with just the root note for the full duration of each chord. Then add rhythm and interest.
   Get the roots right first. Add everything else second.

THE ONE RULE FOR BASSLINES

When the chord changes, the bass note changes to the root of the new chord.

Everything else is rhythm and decoration on top of this rule.

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

PACKET

The Scary Stuff · Part 2: Scales

Part 2 · Day 1

Name _____ Date _____

A scale is an ordered set of notes built using a formula of whole steps (W) and half steps (H). The formula tells you exactly which notes to use. Play each scale on your MPK Mini as you complete it.

C MAJOR SCALE · W - W - H - W - W - W - H ·

Starting on C, apply the formula. The first two notes are done for you.

C	D						(=C)
	W	W	H	W	W	W	H

Play it. Describe what it sounds like in one word: _____

A NATURAL MINOR SCALE · W - H - W - W - H - W - W ·

Starting on A, apply the formula. Fill in all 8 notes.

A							(=A)
	W	H	W	W	H	W	W

Play it. How does it feel different from C Major? _____

ABOUT THE PENTATONIC SCALE

A pentatonic scale removes 2 notes from the major or minor scale, leaving only the ones that sound most agreeable together. WH = one whole step + one half step combined (3 half steps).

C MAJOR PENTATONIC · W - W - WH - W - WH (5 NOTES) ·

C					(=C)
	W	W	WH	W	WH

Which two notes from C Major are missing from C Major Pentatonic? _____ _____

When you finish: your teacher will open the Logic file. Listen to the chords and bassline, then use the notes from C Major or A Minor to write a short melody on top.

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

PACKET

The Scary Stuff · Part 4: Basslines

Part 4 · Days 2–3

Name _____ Date _____

Open the Logic file your teacher provides. A bassline is already written. Before you do anything else, answer the questions below.

LOOK AT THE BASSLINE IN THE PIANO ROLL. ANSWER THESE QUESTIONS ·

What key is this bassline in? _____

What chord is playing in the first section? _____

What note does the bassline play during that chord? _____

Is that note the root of the chord? _____

What happens to the bass note when the chord changes? _____

Write the Roman numeral for each chord in the progression:

Chord 1: _____ **Chord 2:** _____ **Chord 3:** _____ **Chord 4:** _____

THE RULE

When the chord changes, the bass note changes to the root of the new chord.

Everything else — rhythm, extra notes, movement between roots — is decoration on top of this one rule.

NOW WRITE YOUR OWN BASSLINE ·

Choose a chord progression from your Reference Card. Write the Roman numerals and root notes below, then build it in Logic.

CHORD 1	CHORD 2	CHORD 3	CHORD 4
Roman numeral: _____	Roman numeral: _____	Roman numeral: _____	Roman numeral: _____
Root note: _____	Root note: _____	Root note: _____	Root note: _____

Why did you choose this progression? What did you want it to feel like?

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C MAJOR — REFERENCE CARD

The Building Blocks · Unit 4 · Keep this open while you work

SCALE ·

C Major — W - W - H - W - W - W - H

C	D	E	F	G	A	B	C	(8)

CHORDS IN THIS KEY ·

RN	TYPE	CHORD	NOTES	FEELS LIKE...
I	Major	**C Major**	C - E - G	*Home. Settled. Complete.*
ii	Minor	**D Minor**	D - F - A	*Gentle tension. Moving somewhere.*
iii	Minor	**E Minor**	E - G - B	*Wistful. In between.*
IV	Major	**F Major**	F - A - C	*Lifting. Hopeful. Away from home.*
V	Major	**G Major**	G - B - D	*Homesick. Wants to resolve to I.*
vi	Minor	**A Minor**	A - C - E	*Tender. Melancholy. Emotional.*
vii°	Dim.	**B Dim.**	B - D - F	*Tense. Unstable. Rarely used alone.*

Remember: Roman numerals describe chord function, not just chord names.

The I chord always feels like home. · The V chord always feels unresolved. · The vi chord always feels tender or melancholy.

These feelings are the same in every key — only the note names change.

FOR YOUR MELODY

Every note of the scale above is a safe note. Start or end on **C**, the root of the key.

FOR YOUR BASSLINE

The root of each chord is the first note in its Notes column: play it when that chord is playing.

No sharps or flats in this key: every chord is white keys only. A minor uses the same seven notes: it is the relative minor.

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A MINOR — REFERENCE CARD

The Building Blocks · Unit 4 · Keep this open while you work

SCALE ·

A Minor — W - H - W - W - H - W - W

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	A

CHORDS IN THIS KEY ·

RN	TYPE	CHORD	NOTES	FEELS LIKE...
i	Minor	**A Minor**	A - C - E	*Home. But darker and more unsettled than major.*
ii°	Dim.	**B Dim.**	B - D - F	*Tense. Rarely used alone.*
III	Major	**C Major**	C - E - G	*Relative major. Bright moment in a darker key.*
iv	Minor	**D Minor**	D - F - A	*Heavy. Emotional. Pulling back toward home.*
v	Minor	**E Minor**	E - G - B	*Less forceful tension than major V.*
VI	Major	**F Major**	F - A - C	*Warm and open. Common resolution point.*
VII	Major	**G Major**	G - B - D	*Lifting. Drives back toward i strongly.*

Remember: Roman numerals describe chord function, not just chord names.

The i chord always feels like home. · The v and VII chords pull back toward i. · The VI chord feels warm and open.

These feelings are the same in every key — only the note names change.

FOR YOUR MELODY

Every note of the scale above is a safe note. Start or end on **A**, the root of the key.

FOR YOUR BASSLINE

The root of each chord is the first note in its Notes column: play it when that chord is playing.

No sharps or flats in this key: every chord is white keys only. C major uses the same seven notes: it is the relative major.

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Four ways to write a melody

STUDENT

Day 1

Name _____ Date _____

There is more than one way to write a melody. Try at least two of these today. Whichever you use, the rules are the same: 2 or 4 measures, notes from your scale, start or end on the root.

1 PLAY IT IN

Loop 2 measures with Cycle (C). Press R, play on the white keys, stop. Select the notes and press Q to quantize.

Good when you can already hear an idea in your head.

2 DRAW A RHYTHM FIRST

With the Pencil, click notes in a rhythm you like, all on the root. Play it back. Then drag some notes up or down to other scale notes.

Good when you have a groove but no tune yet.

3 CLICK ONE NOTE, MOVE IT

Click in one note. Listen. Drag it up or down until it fits the chord. Then click the next one.

Good when you want to build slowly, one decision at a time.

4 USE THE STEP SEQUENCER

Control-click the track lane and choose Create Pattern Region. Turn steps on to place notes; each row is one pitch.

Good when you want a short, repeating, rhythmic hook.

STUCK?

Use only 3 notes. C major: C, E, G · A minor: A, C, E. Go up, then come back down. That is a melody.

REMEMBER

Simple and repetitive will always beat complicated and forgettable.

The two methods I tried: _____

The one that worked best for me, and why: _____

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Project sheet · melody

STUDENT

Name _____ Date _____

SCALES & MELODY

The Building Blocks · Part 2 · Digital Music Production 1 · Unit 4 · Days 1–2

OVERVIEW ·

You have learned the notes on the keyboard and how whole and half steps work. Now you are going to use a scale — the ingredient list for a key — to write a short melody in Logic. A chord progression and bassline are already provided in the Logic file. Your job is to add a melody on top that stays in key and is short enough to repeat.

WHAT YOU ARE SUBMITTING ·

A short melody written over the provided chord progression and bassline. The melody must be 2 or 4 measures long, stay within the notes of your chosen scale, and be entered into Logic using either the play-in or click-in method.

REQUIREMENTS ·

- ☐ Complete the scale pages in the Scary Stuff packet before opening Logic
- ☐ Choose C Major or A Minor as your scale — white keys only on your MPK Mini
- ☐ Download the provided Logic file — it contains a chord progression and bassline already written
- ☐ Write a melody that is 2 or 4 measures long
- ☐ All melody notes must come from the notes of your chosen scale
- ☐ Melody should start or end on the root note of the key (C for C Major, A for A Minor)
- ☐ Entered using play-in (record + quantize) or click-in (pencil tool)
- ☐ Melody on a separate track with a different sound from the bass
- ☐ Project named: Your Name — Building Blocks Part 2
- ☐ Exported as MP3 and .zip (compressed .logicx file) and submitted to your class page before presenting

HOW TO WRITE A MELODY ·

Keep it short	2 or 4 measures only. Once you have something you like, copy and paste it across the progression. Short melodies are easier to remember and easier to build on.
White keys only	In C Major or A Minor, every white key is a safe note. You cannot play a wrong note if you stay on the white keys.
Give it shape	A good melody goes up for a bit, then comes down — or starts high and descends. Avoid playing the same note over and over, or jumping randomly in both directions.
Start or end on the root	Anchor your melody to C (for C Major) or A (for A Minor). This creates a sense of resolution.
Simple and repetitive wins	A two-note melody with a strong rhythm is more powerful than eight random notes. Write something you could hum after hearing it once.

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Project sheet · tips and checklist

STUDENT

Name _____ Date _____

TIPS FOR SUCCESS ·

- If you cannot find a melody, set a 2-measure loop over the biggest part of the progression and just play around on the white keys. Record anything. You can delete it. The goal is to start.
- Quantize (Q) is not cheating. It fixes timing, not notes. Use it.
- If your melody feels aimless, try this: pick one note and play it in a rhythm you like. Then move one note up or down. Build from there.

SUBMISSION CHECKLIST ·

- ☐ Scale pages in the Scary Stuff packet completed
- ☐ Melody is 2 or 4 measures long
- ☐ All notes from C Major or A Minor scale (white keys only)
- ☐ Melody starts or ends on the root note of the key
- ☐ Entered using play-in or click-in — quantized if played in
- ☐ Melody on separate track with different sound from bass
- ☐ Project named: Your Name — Building Blocks Part 2
- ☐ Exported as MP3 and .zip and submitted to your class page before presenting

GET READY TO PRESENT ·

My key and my root note: _____

My melody goes up, then down? Describe its shape: _____

NOTES ·

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Rubric · melody

RUBRIC

/ 15

Name _____ Date _____

PART 2: SCALES & MELODY — RUBRIC

The Building Blocks · Unit 4 · /15

Each category is scored from 2 to 5.

Category	2	3	4	5	Score
MELODY WRITING	Melody does not stay in key or has no recognizable shape. Cannot be sung back.	Melody stays mostly in key but lacks a clear phrase or contour.	Melody is in key, 2 or 4 measures, and has a recognizable shape. Could be sung back.	Melody is in key, short, starts or ends on the root, and has clear contour. Sounds like it belongs to the progression.	
TECHNICAL SKILL	Notes entered incorrectly or piano roll not used. Play-in material not quantized.	Notes mostly correct but some placement errors or timing issues. Inconsistent use of quantize.	Piano roll used correctly. Notes placed with intention. Quantize applied after play-in.	Piano roll used confidently. Notes are well-placed and well-timed. Both entry methods understood.	
DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION	Not submitted or not presented.	Submitted late or named incorrectly. Minimal presentation engagement.	Correctly named and submitted. Presentation made.	Correctly named, on time. Student explains their melody choices clearly.	
				TOTAL	**/ 15**

MY MELODY CHOICES, IN ONE SENTENCE...

_____

_____

_____

TEACHER COMMENTS

_____

_____

_____

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Project sheet · basslines

STUDENT

Name _____ Date _____

BASSLINES

The Building Blocks · Part 4 · Digital Music Production 1 · Unit 4 · Days 2–4

OVERVIEW ·

You have written a melody and built chords. Now you are going to discover the rule behind every bassline you have ever heard — and write one yourself. Using your Reference Card to choose a chord progression, you will write a bassline that follows the root of each chord and gives the progression its rhythmic foundation.

REQUIREMENTS ·

- ☐ Complete the bassline analysis section of the Scary Stuff packet before writing anything in Logic
- ☐ Choose a 4-chord progression using Roman numerals from your Reference Card
- ☐ Write the root note for each chord before opening Logic
- ☐ Write a bassline that is monophonic throughout — one note at a time, no overlapping notes
- ☐ Root note of each chord used when that chord is playing
- ☐ At least 2 distinct rhythmic ideas in the bassline — not the same note value throughout
- ☐ Progression clearly reflects a harmonic intention — be ready to explain why you chose these chords
- ☐ Project named: Your Name — Building Blocks Part 4
- ☐ Exported as MP3 and .zip (compressed .logicx file) and submitted to your class page before presenting

YOUR CHORD PROGRESSION — PLAN IT HERE ·

Before you open Logic, complete this planning table:

CHORD 1	CHORD 2	CHORD 3	CHORD 4
Roman numeral: _____	Roman numeral: _____	Roman numeral: _____	Roman numeral: _____
Root note: _____	Root note: _____	Root note: _____	Root note: _____

Why did you choose this progression? What did you want it to feel like?

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Project sheet · tips and checklist

STUDENT

Name _____ Date _____

TIPS FOR SUCCESS ·

- Get the root notes right first. Place the root note of each chord for the full duration of that chord before adding anything else.
- A bassline that is too busy is worse than a bassline that is too simple. If in doubt, simplify.
- The rhythm of your bassline is what makes it interesting. Try long notes for slow sections and shorter notes for busier sections.
- Check for overlapping notes in the piano roll. Any overlap in the bass track is an error.

SUBMISSION CHECKLIST ·

- [ ] Bassline analysis section of Scary Stuff packet completed
- [ ] Chord progression planned with Roman numerals and root notes
- [ ] Bassline monophonic throughout — no overlapping notes
- [ ] Root note used at each chord change
- [ ] At least 2 distinct rhythmic ideas in the bassline
- [ ] Written explanation of chord progression choices completed above
- [ ] Project named: Your Name — Building Blocks Part 4
- [ ] Exported as MP3 and .zip and submitted to your class page before presenting

THE ONE RULE

When the chord changes, the bass note changes to the root of the new chord.

NOTES ·

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Rubric · bassline

RUBRIC

/ 15

Name _____ Date _____

PART 4: BASSLINES — RUBRIC

The Building Blocks · Unit 4 · /15

Each category is scored from 2 to 5.

Category	2	3	4	5	Score
BASSLINE CONSTRUCTION	Bassline not monophonic, or root notes absent or wrong. Does not follow chord progression.	Bassline mostly monophonic with some correct root notes, but does not consistently follow chord changes.	Bassline is monophonic. Root note used at each chord change. Some rhythmic variation present.	Bassline is monophonic, follows every chord change, and has a clear rhythmic identity. Feels like it belongs.	
HARMONIC INTENTION	Chord choices appear random. No written explanation or explanation shows no harmonic thinking.	Progression uses correct chords but written explanation is vague. No clear emotional intention.	Progression has a discernible feel. Written explanation describes what student intended.	Progression has a clear emotional character. Student can explain their choices using Roman numeral language.	
DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION	Not submitted or not presented.	Submitted late or named incorrectly. Minimal presentation engagement.	Correctly named and submitted. Presentation made. Planning table completed.	Correctly named, on time. Student presents chord choices using Roman numeral language confidently.	
				TOTAL	**/ 15**

I CHOSE MY PROGRESSION BECAUSE...

_____

_____

_____

TEACHER COMMENTS

_____

_____

_____

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

STUDENT

Key vocabulary

12 words

Name _____ Date _____

Read each word and its meaning. These are the words you should own by the end of the unit.

WORD	MEANING
Scale	an ordered set of notes built with a formula of whole and half steps. The ingredient list for a key.
Key	the home a piece of music settles on: its home note, its scale and its chords (this unit: C major or A minor).
Root	the note a chord is built on, and the home note of a key (C in C major, A in A minor).
Melody	the tune: one note at a time, on top. Short, repetitive and singable.
Contour	the shape of a melody: up for a bit, then down, or high and then descending.
Play-in	recording a part by playing it on a MIDI keyboard (R), then quantizing it (Q).
Click-in	entering notes one at a time with the Pencil tool in the piano roll.
Quantize	snapping notes to the grid. It fixes timing, not notes. It is not cheating.
Bassline	the lowest part. It follows the roots of the chords and gives the music its rhythmic foundation.
Monophonic	one note at a time, with no overlapping notes. Every bassline in this unit is monophonic.
Chord progression	the order the chords come in, written as Roman numerals (I–V–vi–IV) or chord names.
Frequency separation	giving each part its own frequency home so bass and melody do not turn to mud. A high-pass filter on the melody is the first tool.

QUICK CHECK · ANSWERS ON PAGE 27

1. One note at a time, no overlaps: the bassline is _____. _____

2. _____ fixes timing, not notes. _____

3. The note a chord is built on is its _____. _____

4. The shape of a melody, up and then down, is its _____. _____

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Answer key · packet Parts 2 and 4

ANSWER KEY

Teacher

PACKET PART 2 · SCALES

C major: C D E F G A B C
A natural minor: A B C D E F G A
C major pentatonic: C D E G A C
Missing from the pentatonic: **F and B**

PACKET PART 4 · BASSLINE ANALYSIS ·

Answers for the chords-and-bassline file from the setup page (and the Unit 3 worked example). If your file uses other chords, the pattern is the same: the bass plays the root of each chord.

C MAJOR FILE · BASS C – A – F – G

What key is this bassline in?	**C major**
What chord is playing in the first section?	**C Major (I)**
What note does the bassline play during that chord?	**C**
Is that note the root of the chord?	**Yes**
What happens to the bass note when the chord changes?	**It changes to the root of the new chord.**
Roman numerals, chords 1–4	**I – vi – IV – V** (C, Am, F, G)

A MINOR FILE · BASS A – F – C – G

What key is this bassline in?	**A minor**
What chord is playing in the first section?	**A Minor (i)**
What note does the bassline play during that chord?	**A**
Is that note the root of the chord?	**Yes**
What happens to the bass note when the chord changes?	**It changes to the root of the new chord.**
Roman numerals, chords 1–4	**i – VI – III – VII** (Am, F, C, G)

VOCABULARY · QUICK CHECK

1. monophonic · **2.** quantize · **3.** root · **4.** contour

THE 3-NOTE MELODY SET

C major: C, E, G (the notes of the home chord)
A minor: A, C, E (the notes of the home chord)

LISTENING ANSWERS ·

Seven Nation Army (The White Stripes)	The riff is seven notes long with only five different notes (E, G, D, C, B), all from E natural minor, and it repeats over and over. Short, repetitive, singable.
Stand by Me (Ben E. King)	The bass riff starts again on each new chord's root: I – vi – IV – V in A major = A, F#m, D, E. The rule, in a song they know.
Bright or dark?	Most students hear C major as brighter and A natural minor as darker: same seven white keys, a different home note.

The planning table and the why answer have no single right answer. Check that each root is the first note of that chord on the Reference Card, and listen for Roman numeral language in the why.

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

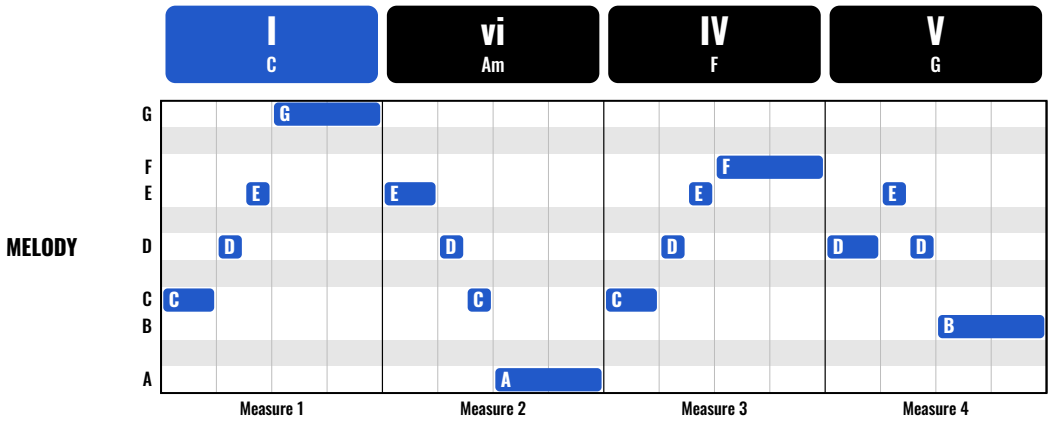
EXAMPLE

Example notes · a worked melody

Teacher

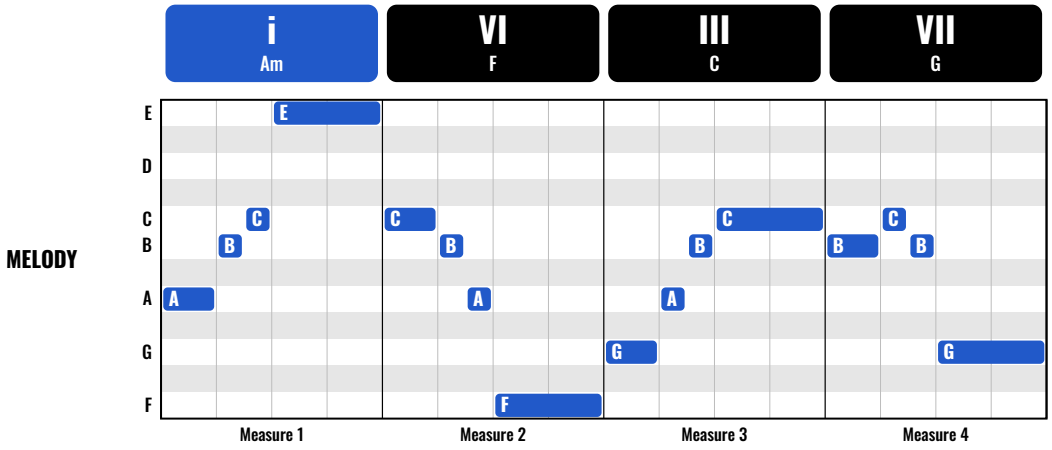
One possible answer for the melody project, over the chords-and-bassline file (one chord per measure); the bass plays each chord's root as a whole note (slide 8 shows both). Same rhythm in every measure: quarter, two eighths, half.

C MAJOR FILE · STARTS ON C ·



MEASURE	CHORD	CHORD NOTES	MELODY	BEATS 1 AND 3 (CHORD NOTES)
1	I	C Major (C - E - G)	C D E G	C, G
2	vi	A Minor (A - C - E)	E D C A	E, A
3	IV	F Major (F - A - C)	C D E F	C, F
4	V	G Major (G - B - D)	D E D B	D, B

A MINOR FILE · STARTS ON A ·



MEASURE	CHORD	CHORD NOTES	MELODY	BEATS 1 AND 3 (CHORD NOTES)
1	i	A Minor (A - C - E)	A B C E	A, E
2	VI	F Major (F - A - C)	C B A F	C, F
3	III	C Major (C - E - G)	G A B C	G, C
4	VII	G Major (G - B - D)	B C B G	B, G

Every note is a white key from the scale. Beats 1 and 3 land on notes of the chord underneath, which is why it sounds like it belongs; the notes between are passing notes from the scale. Shape: up, down, up, down. Copy it, or let students vary it.

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BASS & MELODY WRITING

Example notes · a worked bassline

EXAMPLE

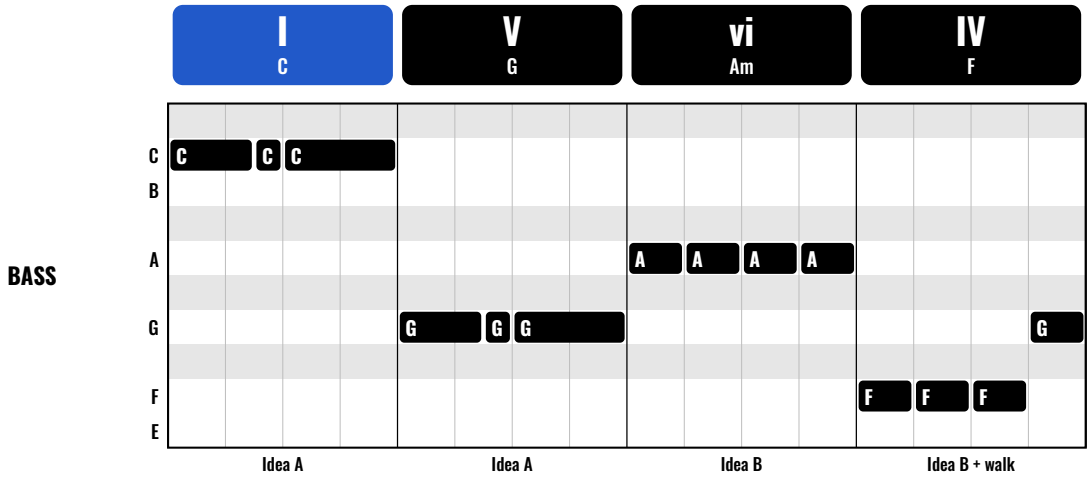
Teacher

One possible answer for the bassline project. Idea A: dotted quarter, eighth, half. Idea B: four quarters. The last note of measure 4 leads into the loop's first chord: G back to C in C major, G up to A in A minor.

C MAJOR · THE PLAN ·

CHORD 1	CHORD 2	CHORD 3	CHORD 4
Roman numeral **I** Root note **C**	Roman numeral **V** Root note **G**	Roman numeral **vi** Root note **A**	Roman numeral **IV** Root note **F**

Why: *I start at home, the V pulls away, the vi turns tender, and the IV lifts it so the loop wants to start again.*



MEASURE	CHORD	ROOT	BASS NOTES	RHYTHM
1	I	C	C C C	Idea A
2	V	G	G G G	Idea A
3	vi	A	A A A A	Idea B
4	IV	F	F F F G	Idea B + walk

A MINOR · THE PLAN ·

i – VI – VII – i (Am, F, G, Am). **Why:** *I start at a darker home, the VI opens it up, and the VII drives back to the i, so it always comes home.*

MEASURE	CHORD	ROOT	BASS NOTES	RHYTHM
1	i	A	A A A	Idea A
2	VI	F	F F F	Idea A
3	VII	G	G G G G	Idea B
4	i	A	A A A G	Idea B + walk

Checks: one note at a time (no overlaps); the root on the first beat of every chord; two rhythm ideas; every note from the scale. A why answer like this one, in Roman numeral language, is what the top level of Harmonic Intention describes.

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